

Planning Statement

Millbrook Solar & Storage – planning application MDC/2026/0412

Liam McAllister · 16 June 2026 · MB-PLN-RPT-0003

1. Introduction

This Planning Statement accompanies the full planning application by Weyland Energy GmbH for the construction, operation and eventual decommissioning of a ground-mounted solar farm of up to 85 MWp with a co-located 20 MW / 40 MWh battery energy storage system (BESS), associated infrastructure, landscaping and biodiversity enhancements on 142 ha of land north of Millbrook village (the Site). The application was submitted to Millbrook District Council on 18 June 2026 and has been given the reference **MDC/2026/0412**.

The Statement explains the proposal, sets out the relevant planning policy and assesses the scheme against it. It should be read together with the Design and Access Statement, the Landscape and Visual Impact Assessment, the Glint and Glare Assessment, the Ecological Impact Assessment, the Biodiversity Net Gain Metric, the Flood Risk Assessment and the Statement of Community Involvement.

2. The Site

The Site consists of eleven arable fields on Ashcombe Farm and Hollins Farm, bounded by Mill Lane to the south, the B4127 to the east and Mill Brook to the west. The land is predominantly Grade 3b agricultural land (moderate quality); 8.6 ha of Grade 3a land in the south-east corner has been excluded from the panel area. Public footpath FP14 crosses the Site from south-west to north-east. There are no statutory landscape or ecological designations on or adjacent to the Site. The Grade I listed St Mary's Church lies 1.1 km to the south.

3. The proposed development

Component	Description
Solar arrays	~ 158,000 bifacial modules on single-axis trackers, max. height 2.9 m
Inverters / transformers	22 skid-mounted inverter stations, 68.4 MWac
Battery storage	20 MW / 40 MWh lithium iron phosphate, 16 containerised units within a 0.9 ha compound
Substation	On-site 33/132 kV substation, max. height 6.5 m
Grid connection	3.8 km underground 132 kV cable to Millbrook 132 kV substation (separate consent by NordGrid)
Access	Construction access via temporary haul road from the B4127; operational access from Mill Lane
Fencing	2.0 m deer fence with mammal gates every 50 m; CCTV on 3 m poles facing inwards
Landscape and ecology	2.4 km new species-rich hedgerow, 12.8 ha wildflower margins, 46 skylark plots
Lifetime	40 years operation, followed by decommissioning and restoration to agriculture

4. Planning policy context

The development plan comprises the Millbrook District Local Plan 2018–2036 and the Millbrook Neighbourhood Plan (made 2021). Local Plan policy CC3 supports renewable energy development where impacts on landscape, heritage, residential amenity and biodiversity are acceptable or can be made acceptable. Policy EN7 requires a biodiversity net gain; the statutory minimum of 10 % now also applies nationally. National policy gives significant weight to the benefits of renewable energy and to the district's declared climate emergency (2019).

5. Assessment of the main issues

5.1 Landscape and visual impact

The LVIA assessed 12 viewpoints agreed with the council's landscape officer. With mitigation in place at year 15, effects are *moderate adverse* at two viewpoints (VP1 footpath FP14, VP3 Mill Lane) and *minor* or *negligible* at the remaining ten. Removing field 7 and widening the FP14 corridor to 30 m keeps the long view from the footpath to St Mary's Church open.

5.2 Glint and glare

Of 34 residential receptors, six have geometric potential for reflections. Single-axis trackers reduce the risk considerably compared with fixed-tilt arrays. Three receptors (R04–R06, Mill Lane Cottages) would experience a *moderate* effect without mitigation; with a 3 m hedgerow screen the residual effect is *none*. No effects on road users of Mill Lane or the B4127 or on aviation were found.

5.3 Highways and construction traffic

Construction is expected to take 12 months with a peak of 64 HGV movements per day in months 3–5. All HGVs will use a temporary haul road from the B4127, so that no construction HGVs pass through the village section of Mill Lane. A Construction Traffic Management Plan (CTMP) is offered as a condition.

5.4 Ecology and biodiversity

The breeding bird survey found 23 skylark territories. The scheme provides 46 skylark plots on retained arable land plus wildflower margins. The biodiversity net gain metric shows **+20.1 % habitat units**, +66 % hedgerow units and +25 % watercourse units.

5.5 Flood risk and drainage

The arrays lie entirely in Flood Zone 1. A small strip along Mill Brook (Flood Zone 2/3) is kept free of infrastructure. The BESS and substation are in Flood Zone 1 with finished floor levels 600 mm above the 1-in-1000-year flood level. Surface water run-off will be reduced by permanent grassland.

5.6 Agricultural land

Sheep grazing between the trackers is proposed, keeping the land in agricultural use. The land can be fully restored at the end of the operational period.

6. Benefits

- 91.3 GWh of clean electricity per year – the equivalent of ~ 26,000 homes
- Battery storage helps balance the local grid and reduces curtailment
- Community fund of EUR 120,000 per year for the lifetime of the project
- Biodiversity net gain of 20 % – double the statutory requirement

- Around 180 construction jobs at peak and local procurement commitments

7. Planning balance and conclusion

The scheme causes limited, localised landscape and visual harm and less-than-substantial harm to the setting of no heritage assets. These are clearly outweighed by the substantial benefits of renewable energy generation, storage, biodiversity gain and community investment. The proposal accords with the development plan read as a whole, and planning permission should be granted subject to conditions.